sting: it includes Garudeshwar taluka panchayat, home to the Statue of Unity. The credit, say observers, goes squarely to Vasava, more than to the AAP symbol. Rather, the latter's street cred here draws substantially from its outspoken tribal leader, not vice versa. It is he who gives flesh and blood to AAP's appeal as an 'outsider' to the system.

The BJP tried both courtship and intimidation with him. Neither has worked so far. Each case it flung at him added to his appeal. Vasava was barred by the high court from entering his constituency as a bail condition until three days before the April 26 polling day. His wives, Shakuntala and Varsha, filled in. The BJP, which has systematically absorbed tribal leaders from the Congress and BTP over the years, found itself outplayed.

Takeaways

- **Gujarat's local body polls again highlighted the importance of Chaitar Vasava, AAP's legislative party leader**
- **In a dramatic campaign under its tribal face, AAP swept most seats in Narmada district, part of the tribal belt**
- **Vasava backs Adivasi demand for a new state, with contiguous parts of tribal concentration in four states**

A STATE OF DESIRE

Tribal communities form around 14 per cent of Gujarat's population, concentrated in a contiguous belt along the state's eastern borders with Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra. This is terrain Vasava is not just reclaiming, but doing so while making the same point as his mentor does: in November 2024, he launched the Bhil Pradesh Mukti Morcha, reviving the decades-old demand for a separate tribal state carved out of tribal districts in these four states, with the Statue of Unity's backyard as the proposed capital.

How does this play out within Gujarat? Its 182-member assembly has 27 ST-reserved seats, and tribal voters are influential in at least another 10. A diligent BJP raised its ST tally from nine seats in 2017 to 23 in the 2022 assembly polls. With focused outreach and winning over the Congress's entrenched tribal veterans, it breached what had been the Grand Old Party's last bastion.

Yet the belt remains restless, with a lingering sense that Gujarat's showcase infrastructure masks their erasure. It engenders a politics that resists the present development model, with its hunger for land, low appetite for compensation, not to speak of provision of jobs, education or health, with a quiet sanskritisation proceeding alongside.

The Congress is historically partial to the tribal sentiment and tries to mobilise around it, but lacks a credible, pan-Gujarat tribal face. That is the space Vasava has stepped into, building credibility without aligning with either the ruling side or its predecessor. It's a perilous, predator-filled course that Adivasi leaders have to navigate.

Chaitar's public life began over a decade ago under the tutelage of Chhotubhai, a kind of Robin Hood figure in Bharuch. The relationship soured after he was denied a BTP ticket in 2022. The BJP claims he first approached them, and joined AAP only after being turned down. In 2024, he contested Bharuch, a general seat. Speculation over his next move is now a staple of conversations. Will the BJP lure him with a ticket to the Lok Sabha? More to the point, will he be amenable? ■

By **Rohit Parihar**

OPIUM WAS HARDLY AN UNKNOWN commodity in old Rajasthan—space existed for it in social rituals and life's ceremonies, in norms of hospitality, in medicine. What's been stalking the land of late, though, are modern mutants, capable of producing hell on an industrial scale. The desert frontier, always a passage as much as a barrier, is turning into an illicit superhighway for drugs and arms—with unmanned aerial delivery. And Rajasthan is transiting fast into a key hub in a transnational narco-terror network.

That is altering the state's behaviour. On the narcotics trade map, it used to be mostly a production and transit zone for opium and poppy husk. But it's transforming into a full-blown consumption market and manufacturing base for synthetic drugs such as mephedrone (MD) and MDMA, a conduit in a widening network that links India's eastern and western borders.

THE AERIAL DELIVERY

If synthetic drugs arrived first, the real accelerant has been drone technology. Border fencing had, for years, restricted traditional smuggling from Pakistan. But traffickers have adapted faster than enforcement. Since 2023, low-flying drones have begun dropping "composite payloads" of narcotics and weapons into Rajasthan's border districts, a pattern first seen in Punjab.

A snapshot came on May 4, with inputs that a Pakistani drone had dropped contraband in Sameja Kothi in Sri Ganganagar district. A high-speed chase led to two smugglers from Punjab, 1.5 kg of heroin and a kilo of opium. These came with five foreign-made pistols—four stamped 'Made in Pakistan', one 'Made in China'—10 magazines and 72 live cartridges.

Earlier this year, the BSF shot down a Chinese-made drone that had crossed over in Bikaner's Khajuwala sector. Its payload included five pistols and 325 cartridges. Vikas Kumar, I-G, Anti-Narcotics Task Force (ANTF), says: "Earlier, drones were used to push heroin. Now, we are seeing weapons."